PEIRTA Newsletter

Prince Edward Island Retired Teachers' Association

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From the President

As a long-awaited spring returns to Prince Edward Island, it brings with it a sense of renewal. We welcome longer days, brighter skies and the promise of new opportunities to connect and move forward together. Although sometimes, life throws a curveball …

In Charlottetown this spring, a quiet but powerful example of community care unfolded around one of our own. At 77, living independently with her loyal dog, she had built a life marked by creativity, independence, daily connection with nature and friends, and the discipline of exercise. But when a fall left her with a broken femur, everything changed in an instant. Surgery was followed by a return home just nine days later, facing a six-month recovery and many weeks in a wheelchair.

What could have been a time of isolation instead became a remarkable expression of friendship and generosity. Friends (and the recommendation of the surgeon) quickly recognized that she could not manage alone and stepped in without hesitation, moving into her home in shifts so she would always have support close by. Daily life—meals, medications, and even caring for her dog—became a shared effort. Beyond her front door, the wider community responded with equal kindness. Meals arrived regularly, each one a reminder that she was held in the care of many.

Even in recovery, she remained connected to the rhythms of her life. Book club discussions and art gatherings continued in adapted ways, bringing laughter, creativity, and a sense of normalcy into her days. These moments, small as they might seem, played a meaningful role in sustaining her spirit.

Support also came through essential services. Provincial Home Care ensured a weekly nurse visit, providing both medical oversight and reassurance. Pat and the elephant provided transportation paid by the customer. After six weeks, she began physiotherapy at the hospital, marking an important step forward in her recovery. Through it all, she approached each day with what she described as an "attitude of gratitude"—deeply appreciative of every visit, every meal, every kind gesture.

That gratitude was matched by her own determination. She committed herself to her recovery exercises with discipline and focus, understanding that healing required both patience and



effort. Even while receiving so much, she continued to give—offering kindness, encouragement, and heartfelt thanks to those around her. It was a reminder that generosity is not diminished by circumstance; it simply takes new forms.

For many retired educators, community has always been at the heart of life's work. In this Charlottetown story, that spirit lives on— caring for each other is a natural way of being —in shared meals, open homes, steady care, and enduring connection. It is a powerful reminder that even in life's most challenging moments, we are never truly alone.

On another note, what has your PEIRTA been up to?

We participated in a video on Basic

See **President, 3**

Visit our website at www.peirta.com

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From the Editor

Retired teachers in PEI have representation at the provincial level, with a voting trustee (Kimball Blanchard) on the Group Insurance Committee, and a voting member (Michel Plamondon) on the Pension Committee. These two bring a wealth of knowledge and experience and aren't afraid to speak up on our behalf.

We also have a voice on the national level, as our president represents us at ACER-CART (Canadian Association of Retired Teachers), the voice for over 160,000 retired teachers in Canada.

These two levels of representation gives us access to advocacy on a range of topics—including pensions, health insurance (drug coverage, trave, and extended insurance benefits), and a variety of issues important to seniors in general.

As an organization, we have several real challenges. One is membership. There are currently almost 1600 retired teachers in PEI. Just over half of these fork out the princely sum of $2 per month to be members of the RTA. We would like to see many more new/recent retirees join—but they have to be convinced it's worth it!

While all retired teachers benefit from the advocacy provided by the RTA, members also have additional benefits. They can participate in decision making by taking on a leadership position as a voting member of the executive, or by participating in the AGM in November (and enjoying a free meal). Between AGMs, they can stay informed by receiving a triannual newsletter.

We are constantly trying to find ways to better serve members and to provide more tangible benefits for them. Recent examples have included reduced golf fees/memberships (Rustico), two curling bonspiels, seven golf tournaments, and, most recently, a ceilidh and a pickleball tournament.

Many of our most active members have been involved for many, many years, and some are approaching a time when they may want to pass over their responsibilities to someone else. I, for example, have edited the newsletter in its current form for 19 years. There will come a time….

We will have a golf tournament this year only if someone is prepared to take on its organization. We hope to try another curling bonspiel in the fall (the one scheduled for March was cancelled this year because we couldn't field the required minimum number of retired teacher curlers—too many conflicts).

If you have any suggestions about how we might better address these challenges, please contact me or any member of the executive.

PEIRTA Executive does not necessarily agree with opinions expressed in material authored by those other than official representatives of the PEIRTA, and information about opportunities offered by others is for information only—no endorsement is implied.

Next issue October, 2026. Submit material to margstewart@pei.eastlink.ca.

If you wish to read this newsletter online instead of receiving a hard copy, send me an email and I will let you know when each issue should appear on our site and on the PEITF site.

Letters to the editor should be a maximum of 200 words, must include a one-line bio, and may be edited for length.

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President (cont'd from 1)

Income Guarantee in collaboration with the Women's Network, sharing our support and perspective as educators.

We attended the Senior Symposium—Seniors Raising Our Voices for Public Services—coordinated by the Cooper Institute, and the four aging-in-place workshops held in Charlottetown

We participate in the monthly Zoom meeting of the Canadian Association of Retired Teachers, and sit on the National Health Committee as well as our Eastern conference of retired teachers (ECRTO.

Cynthia MacDonald brought greetings from PEIRTA and presented a workshop at the pre-retirement seminar in Charlottetown in April, with more than 50 teachers in attendance. On April 26 I brought greetings from PEIRTA to the Summerside pre-retirement seminar. I outlined the benefits of membership (including a golf tournament and curling bonspiel, ceilidh and pickleball tournament), shared the mission, and informed participants about the advocacy at the national level for pharmacare, ageing in place, and the reinstating of a federal minister of seniors position. Marg Stewart did a session on the psychological and social implications of retirement.

We held our first ceilidh at the Benevolent Irish Society on April 19. Jacinta Macdonald and Fullerton's Marsh entertained our members and friends. We thank everyone who participated and the organizing committee—Judy Hughes, Charlene Cain , and Terri Murphy-MacAdam.

The pickleball tournament, also a first initiative, led by Anne Richard and Seanna Evans-Renaud took place on May 8 at the Summerside dome. Well done, athletes.

June 8 to 11, Vice-President Charlene Cain and myself are heading to Vancouver for the Canadian Association of Retired Teachers AGM. We look forward to meeting our colleagues from across the country in person, as well as the guest speakers.The AGM takes place in person every second year.

As we look ahead to the coming months, I encourage everyone to take advantage of the opportunities spring offers—to connect with friends, enjoy the beauty of the Island, and take time for rest and renewal. May this season bring you good health, peace of mind, and many moments of joy. With gratitude for your continued support and for all you have done and continue to do, in service of education and community.

Editor: I have sometimes heard people wonder how good our travel insurance coverage is, and whether one should supplement it with something else if travelling outside the country. The following story, submitted by Sheridyth MacNeil, one of our past presidents, may help answer that question.

A Trip I Will Never Forget

On March 3rd, 2026, I arrived in Costa Del Sol, Spain, with 26 other people on a Target Tours trip.

We had decided to meet for supper that evening at 6:30, and on my way down to the dining room I met two young sisters who were running in the hallway and then decided to play " tag" around me. The next thing I knew the older girl accidentally tripped me and I was on the ceramic floor before I knew what had happened.

I thought at first that I had just badly sprained my left arm above the elbow. When I told everyone the next morning at breakfast what had happened, a nurse in the group offered me a sling, and I used Tylenol to ease the pain.

Unfortunately, my arm started to swell up a few days later and the next thing I knew one of the nurses had booked me an appointment at a medical clinic a few blocks away.

We went there on March 10. After checking my arm they immediately sent me next door to the ER. There, after presenting my Medavie Blue Cross card, which was readily accepted, I had two X-Rays in a hall of 9 X-Ray rooms. Then a radiologist required more extensive X-Rays. Six hours later I was told that I needed surgery.

My first reaction was to tell them I wanted to come home to PEI for my surgery. I came back to my apartment and called Medavie and spoke to Dallia. After saying how sorry she was about my mishap, she told me she would have to talk to the medical team, and would get back to me the next day.

When she called the following day she explained that the Medavie medical team could not allow me to fly back to PEI. On a seven-hour flight from Spain to Montreal, there would be a very high risk of serious blood clots which could be life-threatening. They didn't want to take the chance.

She then set up a Case File for me.

On March 13, Gary Craswell, our trip advisor, came with me to the private hospital recommended by Medavie, Chare Benalmadena Hospital. They asked for my insurance card because they said they had to talk personally to my insurer. Twenty minutes later they came back and said everything was fine. They sent me for blood work, etc. and then said I would be admitted and operated on the next day!

It was quite a hospital. Every room was a private room with a sitting area ,etc. I had fabulous care there. My surgeon was in shortly after the operation and told me I had a double set of fractured bones—one was a shoulder bone and the other was down closer to the elbow. He used 17 staples and then from there made sure I was not in pain. I was discharged the next day at 5 pm.

I stayed on for the rest of my holiday and flew home with the entire group. I have healed very well, and am so happy about how everything played out.

Tales from an on-call teacher's classroom

After a full-time teaching career at the secondary school level, Beverley Smith (Calgary, Alberta) worked as a K-12 on-call teacher for several years. She has published an e-book of stories derived from that experience. Her stories are funny, moving, sometimes shocking—and will be in many ways familiar. As space permits, I plan to publish some of these stories for your reading pleasure.

Here's part of her introduction.

I got to see teacher creativity, from the bare classrooms with straight desks and nothing on the walls, to the Spanish café theme bilingual room loaded with mobiles and pictures of Mexico. Some classrooms were literally works of art. I marvelled at the colour-coded Grade 1 room where every child had their own matching file folders, cubbies for supplies and desk ID. One was clearly the room of an artist, with everything in black-and-beige wicker, nearly a meditative spa space. I knew there was no budget for such decorating. Some teachers had just chosen to spend their money this way.

I worked at sturdy 1920s wooden teacher desks and at supermodern blue ones; some messy, some perfectly bare but with instruction notes. I got to admire teachers yet again. Some were dealing with really huge classes, balky defiant students who frankly got worse for subs because why not? Yet other schools treated subs like gold, announced on the PA to the school that today there was a "guest teacher" in the school and they should all be on their best behaviour. Grade 8 kids who on seeing a sub cheered, Grade 11s who high-fived each other that it was game on, and yet little Grade 1s who cried, distressed that the regular teacher was gone.

Heartbreaking moments. The Grade 1 girl who, crying, whispered that she missed her mother. I reassured her that she'd soon get to go back home and see her, but then she told me her mother had died. She was rubbing the necklace her dad had given her to rub when she felt lonely. I remember well the little boy who was crying and, when asked, told me that his dog had been hit by a car. Suddenly my mission was not so much to teach carry-the-one in math, but to comfort.

Public Services: Seniors Raising Our Voices

(*report submitted by Lise Morin)*

The recent project **Seniors' Voice for Public Services** had two components. The first was a 15-hour training program on a wide range of aspects of public services as basic collective human rights—examining in general the characteristics and nature of public services, using the examples of Health, Housing, and the Social Safety Net. This first part took place in October-November, 2025 with eleven seniors participating. The second phase was the preparation and presentation of a community-wide symposium with 51 participants attending on February 28, 2026.

Symposium Objectives

— to identify what people already know about public services
—to increase our knowledge about public services (advantages and challenges)
—-to find ways of taking part in ongoing action of the PEI Coalition for Public Service

What did we know?

—that the Seniors' Secretariat has printed a "Seniors' Guide: Information about programs and services for seniors. The guide is widely distributed
—that there is a 211 phone line–a 24/7 live answer navigation service that connects callers to non-profit, community, and government programs
—that when our public services are well-funded everyday life is better, people's basic needs are met, and there are fewer acute crises

What are some of the challenges?

—the Senior Navigator is helpful; but most Islanders don't know about this service
—under-funded not-for-profit organizations do some of the work that governments should be doing
— public services are hard to access due to long wait lists, lack of transportation, disabilities etc. There should be a central location or hub that people can visit or email to find out about available programs.
—Specific issues mentioned included access to mental and physical health care and comprehensive dental care; transportation and mobility; personal safety; isolation; food insecurity; literacy; housing, especially in rural areas; affordable community care; computer and internet access; cancellation of programs or tightening of eligibility requirements; support from public servants and politicians.

How can seniors (and others) add their voices to the work of the PEI Coalition for Public Services?

—join a political party or campaign; lobby government for a Seniors advocate; get and stay informed (social newsletters, forums, meetings, etc.); spread the word;
—-identify advocates from among larger groups; collaborate with like-minded groups; engage media, Seniors College, immigrant groups, politicians.







Pickleball is the only sport where you can be wildly competitive… while wearing a sun visor, sipping iced tea, and calling someone "sweetheart" mid-smash!

PEIRTA Pickleball Tournament ~ *by Anne Richard*

PEIRTA's first pickleball tournament was held on Friday, May 8 at the Dome in Summerside and from all comments it was a great overall success!

Our retired teachers/players travelled from Souris to Tignish and many places in between. So awesome to see familiar faces and meet new ones.

The chatter, laughs, and camaraderie brought back great memories of staff get togethers:)

Play was on five courts (4 per court) and everyone played six games. Amazing talent and some close competitive games!

A special thank you to Seana Evans Renaud for reaching out to RK4 who provided prizes of 6 mesh bags and 3 high end paddles. One mesh bag with blue print was found. If it is yours, you can text me at 902-303-5321.

A huge thank you to all who travelled and came to play. Our tournament couldn't have happened or have been so incredible without each one of you! Looking forward to the next tournament whenever and wherever.

Wishing all a wonderful and safe summer!

Play golf!

A huge thank you to David Saunders who recently informed me that Rustico Resort will once again this year offer a significant benefit to RTA members.

Play Monday to Thursday after 11a.m. for half the regular green fee.

For tee times: https://www.chronogolf.com/club/1373/widget?medium=widget&source=club

For Dahlia restaurant: https://www.rusticoresort.com/restaurant



RTA Ceilidh with *Fullerton's Marsh*



Holland College Bursary Winners

This year's winners of PEIRTA Early Childhood and Education bursaries are Piper Mehlitz and Kloe Robinson.

Piper is from St. Peter's Harbour. In her thank you note to the PEIRTA, she writes the following: "I have been extremely proud and blessed with starting my journey of Early Childhood Education, and I have made connections and friendships with such amazing, beautiful, and wonderful people who have supported me and guided me to continue my journey to become an Early Childhood educator. ...Thank you so much from the bottom of my heart."

Kloe is from Kinkora, PE, and writes "Thank you for selecting me for the PEI Retired Teachers Association Bursary! I was so happy and appreciative to learn of my selection for this award. This bursary will significantly alleviate the financial burden of my tuition fees, allowing me to focus on my studies and less on finances."



Mother: "Johnny, if you keep being this naughty, you'll get kids who will be very naughty to you!" Little Johnny: "Oh , Mom, you just betrayed yourself there, didn't you?"

IMPORTANT UPDATE REGARDING YOUR PEITF GROUP INSURANCE CLAIMS PROCESSING *~by Nadia Roze, Senior Consultant, belairdirect*

We would like to inform retired members of the PEITF Group Insurance Plan of an upcoming change to the administration of benefit claims.

Effective October 1, 2026, claims adjudication and processing will transition from belairdirect to Medavie Blue Cross.

This change is intended to streamline the claims experience for members.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN FOR YOU?

Your current benefit coverage, eligibility and reimbursement levels will remain unchanged. The primary change is how your claims will be submitted, processed and administered.

Beginning October 1st:

- Members will be able to use their current Medavie Blue Cross Drug card for all other Health and Dental claims.
- Existing direct billing arrangements will continue with minimal disruption. Simply show your current Medavie Blue Cross Drug Card to your service provider when you pay. They will apply the change and continue with direct billing.
- For claims where providers do not offer direct billing, claims will be submitted to Medavie Blue Cross, either through their online portal, mobile app, or by mail.

Additional transition details and instructions will be shared with members in advance of the change.

WHAT YOU NEED TO DO?

At this time, no immediate action is required.

Please watch for:

- Additional communication regarding the transition including registration instructions for online access.

Please note that belairdirect will remain your plan administrator and will continue providing support with address changes, adding or removing dependents, retirement status updates, beneficiary changes, etc.



Address Changes

If your address changes, or if you know anyone who has had a change of address and/or is not receiving this newsletter, please have him or her notify our membership chair (contact info on page 2). Your mailing address must include a civic address and/or PO Box number, and a postal code. Going forward, if you would like to read this newsletter online instead of getting a hard copy, send the editor an email with your request.

Prince Edward Island Teachers' Federation

Andy Doran



As I write this article the outside temperature is 22 degrees. Just a few days ago it snowed and overnight temperatures fell to-5 degrees. So much for the spring season! The common observation that PEI weather often goes from winter to summer has certainly proven true this year.

On May 28 at Clinton Hills the Public Schools Branch will be hosting its annual retirement dinner. Fifty-six teachers will be joining your ranks as retired teachers at the end of the year. For some teachers this decision has been an easy one. They are confident that the time has come and have started making plans for the next stage in their lives. For others, this decision has been a difficult one. Not everyone has all their ducks in a row and are excited about such a big lifestyle change. Around the office, teachers visit the Federation building to talk with Ryan about retirement. For some, you can see the stress and worry on their faces. A difficult decision for sure. It is really helpful for teachers to know that we have a Retired Teachers' Association that is very well organized, supportive and there to keep teachers connected to a familiar network of colleagues and help make this important transition.

Last weekend I had the pleasure of attending the Nova Scotia Teachers Union Annual Council (equivalent to our AGM). Witnessing first hand how another organization conducts their union business was fascinating. There were things NSTU does that I wished we did as an organization. For example, they open their AGM with an elaborate land acknowledgement and tribute to the many cultural groups in Nova Scotia. It also made me appreciate our own way of doing things—in a way reaffirming our practices while acknowledging there is always room for improvement. Pension indexing for example, is a success for retired PEITF members and a source of frustration for retired NSTU members.

I had the pleasure of meeting Pat Hillier, President of the Nova Scotia Retired Teachers Association. We chatted about how retired teachers are crucial to both provinces with regards to substituting. Without retired teachers both provinces would be in a substitute crisis. She also described to me how their association is organized and how it serves its members. Very similar to the great work that our RTA is doing for the retired teachers of PEI.

In the next couple of months keep your eye out for a PEITF media campaign that is called, "Made Possible by Teachers." This campaign highlights the positive impact that teachers have on our students' lives. Teachers have always, and continue to, bring the best out in our students and set them on a path for success. This campaign will be a lead-up to a bargaining year when we, as a Federation, will continue to try and achieve meaningful improvements for classroom working conditions through the collective bargaining process for PEI teachers.

Have a great summer.



PEI RTA Annual Golf Tournament

For seven years Wayne Denman almost single-handedly organized and ran our retired teachers' golf tournament. Wayne has other commitments this year, so unless someone else steps up we will not have a tournament this year, and maybe never again!

Thank you so much, Wayne. I played in them all, and had a ball!

The organizing committee would have to work with a course to get an attractive green/cart fee for all players; make decisions about date, format, prizes, food (if any); manage registrations; design a draw; and have someone "in charge" the day of the tournament. Any other details would be up to the committee (fund raiser component, games. entertainment, etc., or none of the above).

Since this tournament was originally planned to offer something tangible to RTA members, and is sponsored by the PEIRTA, there would have to be a minimum number of retired teachers registered, RTA members would have to have a reduced green fee, and a proposal, with a proposed budget. would have to be approved by the executive.

If anyone can put together a group to make another tournament possible, send me (Marg) an email and I'll look after publicity (posters in every club).

Check your club bulletin board regularly throughout the summer to see whether anything is happening.

Fast Forward Since 1925

Here's a short list of the new things that appeared in our lives over the last hundred years. (CSA News, from various sources)

Television
Microwave oven
Computer and internet
Electric chainsaw
Refrigeration and frozen food
Aerosol spray can
Artificial heart
Barbie doll
Chocolate chip cookies
Video game
LED light bulb
Photocopy machine
Nylon
Penicillin
Scotch tape
Sliced bread
DNA profiling

Retired Teachers' Curling Bonspiel



Our curling bonspiel scheduled for March had to be cancelled. Because this event is sponsored by the PEIRTA, we require that we must have at least two retired teachers on every team. We ran into conflicts with travel and another curling event, and could not meet that requirement (incidentally, we had lots of Cornwall curlers happy to fill up the teams).

We hope to try again in November. Two possible dates are November 6 and November 20— which will depend on the scheduling of another bonspiel which takes priority.

If you're interested, keep these dates open. We'll have information in every club as soon as they open. Prior to that, if you're wondering what's happening give me (Marg) a call or send me an email.

PEITF Travel Insurance

Our out-of-province travel insurance plan has a 90-day medical stability clause. This means that if you have a pre-existing medical condition, it must be considered medically stable for 90 days prior to your departure date if you are to be covered in the event of a medical emergency related to this condition while you are travelling.

A pre-existing condition is considered stable if the member, in the 90 days before the departure date, has not:

1. Been treated or evaluated for new symptoms or related conditions;
2. Had symptoms that increased in frequency or severity, or examination findings indicating the condition has worsened; .
3. Been prescribed a new treatment or change in treatment for the condition.
4. Been admitted to a hospital for the condition; or
5. Been awaiting new treatments or tests regarding the medical condition (does not include routine tests).

Number 3 generally does not include reductions in medication due to mprovement in a condition, or regular changes in medication as part of an established treatment plan—but each case must be reviewed individually. Call Medavie Blue Cross at 1-800-667-4511, Travel Department, for clarification if you are planning to travel outside PEI.

MEDAVIE BLUE CROSS